FREE GUIDE · UPDATED OCT 2026

BUYER GAME PLAN

Four missions to finish before you tour a single house. One more for after your offer. Worksheets and official links inside.

Start with mission 1



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REALTOR

EQUAL HOUSING OPPORTUNITY

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

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Do the missions in order. Each one ends with something you can fill in or ask for. Tap any line to jump to it. Buttons open official sites. New missions are added to this guide over time, and the link you got stays the same.

01 Mission 1: Get pre-approved — Documents and lender questions

02 Mission 2: Know your payment — Worksheet and a real example

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The mission. Walk into your first tour with four things done: a lender's real number, a payment you can live with, a short list of what you need in a house, and a buyer agreement you understand. Then every house is a decision, not a guess.

This guide is general education, not legal, tax or lending advice. Rules, rates and programs change. Confirm with your lender, your attorney and the official links before you act.

MISSION 1

01 GET PRE-APPROVED

Pre-approved means a lender checked your income, credit and savings and put a number on paper. Pre-qualified is a quick estimate. Sellers take a pre-approval seriously. It also tells you your real price range before you fall for a house.

BRING THESE TO YOUR LENDER

- ☐ Photo ID
- ☐ Pay stubs, last 30 days
- ☐ W-2s, last 2 years (tax returns if self-employed)
- ☐ Bank and savings statements, last 2 months
- ☐ List of debts and monthly payments
- ☐ Rent history or landlord contact

MILITARY AND VETERANS

- VA loan: ask for a Certificate of Eligibility
- Active duty: statement of service. Veterans: DD-214
- VA funding fee for first use with no down payment is 2.15%. Veterans with a 10% or higher service-connected disability rating are exempt
- Ask about SC Housing first-time buyer programs. Funding is limited and changes

ASK YOUR LENDER THESE 5 QUESTIONS

- What price range do you approve me for?
- What is my interest rate and my APR?
- What is my total cash to close?
- Is there a rate lock, and for how long?
- What could change my approval before closing?

VA home loans | Request your COE | SC Housing programs | Loan guide (CFPB)

Get quotes from at least two lenders in the same week. Credit checks for a mortgage inside a short window are usually grouped, so shopping rates is fine. Ask your lender how this works for your file. Check the VA page for the current funding fee table.

MISSION 2

02 KNOW YOUR PAYMENT

A pre-approval tells you what a lender will lend. Your budget tells you what you should borrow. Price the whole payment, not just principal and interest.

YOUR WORKSHEET

Price you are considering	$ _____
Down payment	$ _____
Loan amount	$ _____
Interest rate (from lender)	_____ %
Principal and interest	$ _____
Property tax, per month	$ _____
Homeowners insurance	$ _____
HOA dues	$ _____
Mortgage insurance, if any	$ _____
Total monthly payment	$ _____

EXAMPLE ONLY

Price **$300,000**
Down payment 5% **$15,000**
Loan **$285,000**
Rate **7.32%**, 30-year fixed
Principal and interest **about $1,958 a month**

A quarter point higher (7.57%) is about **$2,006**. That is about $49 more a month, about $590 a year.

7.32% is the Freddie Mac national 30-year average for Oct 22, 2026. It is not a quote. Your rate depends on your credit, down payment and loan type. Taxes, insurance, HOA and mortgage insurance are on top of the example.

South Carolina tip. The home you live in can be taxed at a lower rate than a rental or second home. In SC it is called the legal residence rate, a 4% assessment instead of 6%. In Lexington County you apply after you own and occupy the home. Confirm the steps and the deadline with the County Assessor, 803-359-8000. Ask your agent to use a tax estimate for an owner-occupied home when you compare houses.

Lexington County legal residence | Loan guide (CFPB) | Find a housing counselor

MISSION 3

03 WRITE YOUR MUST-HAVES

Decide before you tour. Fill in what the house must have, what would be nice, and what is a no. Keep it to what you can see and measure. Bring this page to your first tour.

MUST HAVE	NICE TO HAVE	NO WAY
Bedrooms: ____	Fenced yard	
Bathrooms: ____	Garage	
Max drive to work: ____ min	Primary on main	
Max monthly payment: $____	Office or flex room	
	Pool or lake access	

CHECK BEFORE YOU FALL FOR A HOUSE

- ☐ Age of the roof, HVAC and water heater
- ☐ Flood zone and insurance cost
- ☐ HOA rules, dues and fees
- ☐ Drive the route to work at your real hour
- ☐ Property tax estimate for owner-occupied

BEFORE YOU TOUR

- Send your must-haves to your agent
- Ask for the pre-approval letter to be ready
- Tour 3 to 5 homes in one day, same area
- Take photos and notes at every house
- Review your list after each tour

Fair housing: I show homes by your price, features and location needs. I do not steer buyers toward or away from neighborhoods. For schools, crime or other local facts, use the official source and decide for yourself.

MISSION 4

04 READ THE BUYER AGREEMENT

Since Aug. 17, 2024, REALTOR MLS participants have to sign a written agreement with a buyer before touring a home. South Carolina also requires the Disclosure of Brokerage Relationships form before an agent shows a property. Ask these 7 questions of any agent, including me.

1. **How long does it last?**
   Ask for the start date, end date, and how either side can end it early in writing.

2. **What is the fee, and how is it paid?**
   It must be stated clearly as an amount or a rate. It cannot be "whatever the seller offers." It is negotiable.

3. **What if the seller pays part or all of it?**
   Ask how that reduces what you owe. Your agent cannot be paid more than the agreed amount from any source.

4. **What does it cover?**
   Which areas, which price range and which property types. Are new builds and for-sale-by-owner homes included?

5. **What does the agent do for me?**
   Ask for the duties in plain language: tours, offers, negotiation, inspections, paperwork, closing.

6. **What if I want out?**
   Ask what happens if you want a different agent, or the agent is not doing the job.

7. **What happens after it ends?**
   Ask if any fee applies to a home you saw before the end date.

Sources: NAR "Written Buyer Agreements 101" and the SC Real Estate Commission guidance (Oct 11, 2024). This is general information, not legal advice. If something is unclear, ask for time and have an attorney review it.

SC Real Estate Commission guidance

MISSION 5 · AFTER YOUR OFFER IS ACCEPTED

05 CASH, DATES AND CLOSING

A signed contract starts a clock. Know what you pay, when you pay it, and who does what. In South Carolina an attorney handles your closing.

MONEY YOU WILL NEED

Earnest money, with contract	$ _____
Home inspection	$ _____
Appraisal (lender orders)	$ _____
Down payment	$ _____
Closing costs and prepaids	$ _____
Total cash to close	$ _____

Your lender's Loan Estimate shows your closing costs. Ask for the final numbers before closing day.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

- Earnest money is due as the contract says
- Inspection period: inspect, then ask for repairs or a credit
- Lender orders the appraisal and finishes underwriting
- Do not open new credit or change jobs. Do not make large unexplained deposits
- Set up utilities and homeowners insurance
- Final walk-through before closing
- Closing with your attorney. Bring ID and the funds as instructed

The rule. Do not move money, open credit or change jobs between contract and closing without calling your lender first. A change in your credit, income or deposits can stop a loan after you are under contract.

MISSION TRACKER

CHECK OFF EACH MISSION

Mark each mission as you finish it. Bring this page to your first tour, or send me a photo of it and I will pick up where you left off.

	MISSION	DATE
☐	Mission 1: Get pre-approved	Done on: _____
☐	Mission 2: Know your payment	Done on: _____
☐	Mission 3: Write your must-haves	Done on: _____
☐	Mission 4: Read the buyer agreement	Done on: _____
☐	Mission 5: After your offer is accepted	Done on: _____

New missions. I add missions to this guide as new buyer questions come up. The link you got stays the same, so check back for new ones. Comment MISSION on my Monday posts and I will send you the latest version.

YOUR NEXT STEP

READY TO PUT THE PLAN TO WORK?

Tell me which mission you are on. I will help you with the next one. No pressure and no cost to ask.

Start here: 2-minute form



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Equal housing opportunity. This guide is general information. It is not legal, tax or lending advice. Rates, programs and rules change. Confirm details with your lender, your attorney and the official sources linked in this guide.